was an early expression of the idea of trophic cascades, although he himself did not use that term.

Predators help keep a balance in a food web by regulating the populations of other animals. When they attack and eat prey, they affect the number and behavior of that prey. For example, prey may move away, feed less, or even spend time inspecting the predator when predators are present. The impact of a predator can extend down to the next feeding level (trophic level), affecting the population of the prey's own food source. In essence, by controlling the population density and behavior of their prey, predators indirectly benefit and increase the abundance of their prey's prey.

Indirect interaction that occurs across feeding levels is described by ecologists as a trophic cascade. By definition, trophic cascades must cross at least three feeding levels. Four- and five-level trophic cascades are also known, although these are less common.